

KF Mini-Meeting Lesson 27

--"MINI-MEETING" FORMAT-- (20 min)

I - MINDFULLNESS (4 min)

-ANB (1 min)

-3 Minute Breathing Space (3 min)

II - CHECK-IN (10 min)

-KF Member "A" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

-KF Member "B" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

III - KF MEETING "PREVIEW" (6 min)

-Bible Teaching -- selected excerpt of previous week KF Bible teaching (5 min)

-Ending Prayer (1 min)

BIBLE TEACHING

We often perceive as real limitations the illusions that we foster in order to save the life of our Idol Self. Last week we talked about the illusions created by appearances, talent, and money. We saw how distracted we are by the ATM of others and learned from James that the only real asset is faith—that is, *action based on oriented beliefs*. We also considered how the ATM can be used to support illusions of effortless superiority and the *if onlys* of limitless possibilities. For example, we might think, “If only I had enough money, I could stop my body ageing. We are often hoodwinked by the ATM rather than guided by realities.

In chapter 12 of Second Corinthians, we will see how Paul deals with some of his imagined limitations. This passage is famous for encouraging many Christians to revel in imagined limitations and use their perceived weak areas as an excuse for not developing their true potential in Christ. Nancy’s paraphrase of **Second Corinthians 12:7–10** is based on her own translation and offers alternative insights. Let’s listen to it now.

2 Corinthians 12:7-10

⁷In order that I might not raise my True Self up to actualization, and because of the loftiness of those revelations about my potential in Christ, I was given a thorn in the flesh by the Idol Self, a messenger that Satan uses to slap me down, so that I cannot raise myself up to the height of my true potential. ⁸Three times I called on the Lord to encourage me about this thorn of imagined limitation so that it might be sent away from me. ⁹And He said to me, “My gift of karis relationship is sufficient for you to reach your real potential. Look at it this way. Active energy is matured in frailties. In other words, weaknesses or lack of skill is not to be avoided for fear of self-hate, but to be acknowledged and trained, so that your real abilities may have more effect with less effort.”

¹⁰With greatest pleasure, therefore, I have confidence in my real weaknesses rather than in my imagined strengths, so that the ability of Christ to train and strengthen me might dwell with strategic force in me. Because of Christ’s ability to train me, I have a positive attitude in weakness, in self-hate, in necessities, in persecution, and whenever I am in tight spots on behalf of Christ. It’s like this: when I feel weak in my Idol Self, at the same time I, in my True Self, am very capable.

Take a deep breath.

Rather than imagining that Satan, the Idol Self, and life events have the power to limit him, Paul takes the position of regarding all life experiments as opportunities to train. He has learned to let go of making his limitations the excuse for remaining in the dreary pasture of his Idol's comfort zone. Instead, he embraces his weaknesses, trusting in Christ's ability to train him into a growing *God-confidence* and courage. Rather than going into self-hate each time an area of weakness is exposed, Paul welcomes weakness as an opportunity to explore and grow. Having a need for training is not a limitation; it is a gift. Paul is eager to courageously explore his weakness in order to give God the opportunity to make him strong—strong with the strength inherent in God's design. In the process of becoming strong, Paul breaks through the electric fence of his imagined limitations and discovers his real limitations. This ongoing discovery strengthens his self-confidence in every area of his life.

All real growth is stressful. Let's hear that again. All real growth is stressful. You cannot pick up true glory on the bargain table—there are no shortcuts to developing strength and maturity. That's why very few people are interested in real growth. In order to grow, we must move out of the comfortable land of predictable miseries and unsatisfying pleasures and courageously step into the stresses of wandering in an unknown wilderness without skill or familiarities—but with hope. Through our experience of navigating this unfamiliar territory, we gain confidence and our faith is strengthened. All the ground that we cover becomes familiar territory. Experiments become experience, and life is no longer scary because we have real, tested skills. The struggle against the internal resistance of imagined limitations can be extremely productive. In that struggle we grow strong; we develop real tested skills that God and everyone else can trust.

Let God, our Trainer, decide when it is time for you to rest and when it is time for you to continue the journey. He will not push you beyond your capabilities, but He is eager to see you grow. As you continually stretch both your internal and external capacities, you grow from faith to faith, from trust to trust, and from glory to glory. Each time you are launched into a new challenge, you will begin with more hope and courage than you had before. You cannot be perfect because you are eternally developing creature. Perfection is finite, and the karis relationship with God is infinite.

Our prayer might go something like this:

My Trainer, I am more interested in karis with You than in my imagined limitations. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are grateful for this opportunity to train and heal. Redirect the power of this energy toward our potential and toward an authentic life that declares what You created us to be. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.